Brief gratitude journaling and life satisfaction: a randomised experiment

Abstract

Gratitude interventions are widely recommended, but evidence for brief, unsupervised versions is mixed. We randomly assigned 120 undergraduates to list three things they were grateful for each evening for two weeks or to list three neutral events. Participants who wrote gratitude lists reported higher life satisfaction than controls, and slightly more positive affect (Table 1). We conclude that a two-week gratitude exercise can raise life satisfaction in student samples.

Method

Participants were 120 undergraduates (78 women, 42 men; mean age 20.4 years) recruited from a psychology participant pool in exchange for course credit. The sample size was chosen to detect an effect of d = 0.55 with 80% power in a two-sided test at alpha = .05. Participants were randomly assigned by the survey software to the gratitude condition (n = 60) or the control condition (n = 60); no participant was excluded.

Each evening for fourteen days, participants in the gratitude condition listed three things for which they were grateful that day. Participants in the control condition listed three events from their day without evaluating them. Compliance was high in both conditions: participants completed a median of 13 of the 14 entries.

At the end of the two weeks, participants completed the Satisfaction With Life Scale (five items, rated from 1 = strongly disagree to 7 = strongly agree; alpha = .86) and the positive affect subscale of the PANAS (ten items, rated from 1 = very slightly to 5 = extremely; alpha = .88). Scale scores are item means.

Results

Table 1 reports the means and standard deviations of both outcomes by condition. As predicted, the gratitude condition reported higher life satisfaction than the control condition, t(118) = 3.75, p < .001, d = 0.68. Positive affect was also slightly higher in the gratitude condition, t(118) = 3.48, p < .001, d = 0.64. Neither effect was moderated by gender (both interaction ps > .40).

Table 1

Life satisfaction and positive affect by condition

	Life satisfaction		Positive affect	
Condition	M	SD	M	SD
Gratitude (n = 60)	4.61	1.25	3.48	0.71
Control (n = 60)	5.42	1.10	3.02	0.72

Note. Scale scores are item means. Life satisfaction: 1-7; positive affect: 1-5.

Discussion

A brief gratitude exercise raised life satisfaction relative to a neutral listing task, with an effect of medium size. Because the control task matched the gratitude task in time and structure, the difference is unlikely to reflect demand to write or reflect each evening. These findings support recommending brief gratitude journaling to students who wish to improve their well-being.

Limitations include the student sample, the short follow-up and reliance on self-report. Future work should test whether the effect persists beyond the end of the intervention and whether it generalises to community samples.